Sparc Design Challenge: Napkin Pitches

The Big Idea

Interactive and higher quality job postings where recruiters are encouraged to include FAQs from the beginning, such as dates for the hiring process, start date, etc, and a public forum below each job listing where prospective candidates can ask questions.

Additional feature where you can view job listings side by side and AI can compare and contrast positions with each other and your resume.

Usability

It makes it easier for students to get their questions about each position answered and also limits the amount of messages a recruiter has to manage. Additionally, this allows candidates to more easily see what jobs their experience lines up to and how to possibly improve their resumes.

This creates a feedback loop where questions from students can improve the quality of future job postings and also students receive feedback on how they can improve their resumes

Feasibility

An interactive forum under job listings can be implemented with existing web development tools and databases. Hence, it is quite feasible to implement it. It would require additional sections to be added to the current job posting from the employer side for FAQs. And discussion forum for students and employers.

Viability

In feedback received in the team's informational interviews, students expressed frustration about lacking information about roles and companies they were looking at, and companies expressed frustration that the people they hired showed up without enough knowledge about what the company does and what they'd be working on in their role. This is an incredibly desirable change to how job postings are done and would make Sparc an attractive platform to search on.

The Big Idea

Calendar feature for Sparc-wide events that all users can attend. Clubs can request events like resume review, networking, hackathon etc with companies so it is a 2-way process. More resources/event types from companies to show off what working there is like through virtual tours etc.

Usability

All the users can have a detailed view of all upcoming events they can attend, making it easy to plan their schedules and take advantage of growth opportunities.

Feasibility

For Calendar feature, it's completely feasible as it would be an additional representation of the events conducted on Sparc. For Clubs to request events with companies, will be an additional feature provided to the student groups is feasible.

Viability

Adding this feature to their platform would not need much modification in the existing system. Also, this feature adds unique value when compared to the competitors by supporting company-student interactions that go beyond job postings, promoting a strong connection with the company. Hence, this can attract more users to the platform.

The Big Idea

Sparc can search for clubs and universities to partner with in a more broad way. Rather than contacting clubs, Sparc can contact the staff club coordinator at each university and have them disseminate information to clubs and organize an event. Additionally having a more formal connection with universities can extend deeper: Sparc can connect start-ups with professors who can become advisory board members.

More broadly, Sparc could contact multi-university consortiums or associations , which are when the same programs at multiple universities network together like MEMPC. These consortiums host regular meetings and Sparc can find a way to get in touch with each organization based off what the needs of his company clients are. This would allow Sparc to connect with more students at once.

Usability

This new recruitment methodology is just a change in tactic of the establish methodology used by Sparc to attract clubs and universities to their platform. Additionally, showing an increase in the amount of clubs onboarded will allow for Sparc to more easily establish more meaningful connections with multiple companies.

Feasibility

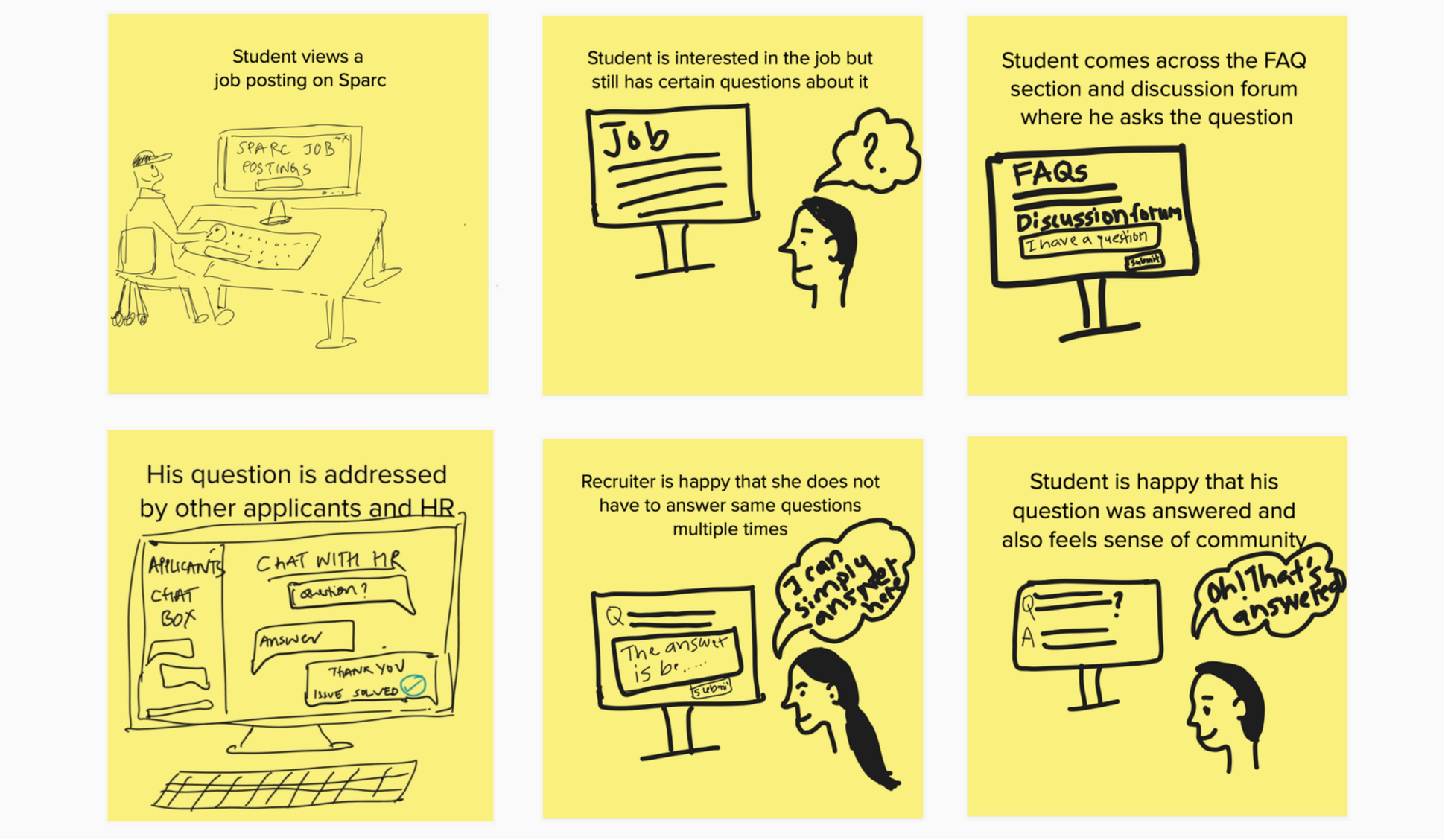
This idea is not financially heavy, its easy to connect and spread the word.
Partnering with multi-university networks like MEMPC helps Sparc reach many schools at once, saving time and effort. Using existing systems and digital tools keeps costs low and makes connecting with students straightforward.

Viability

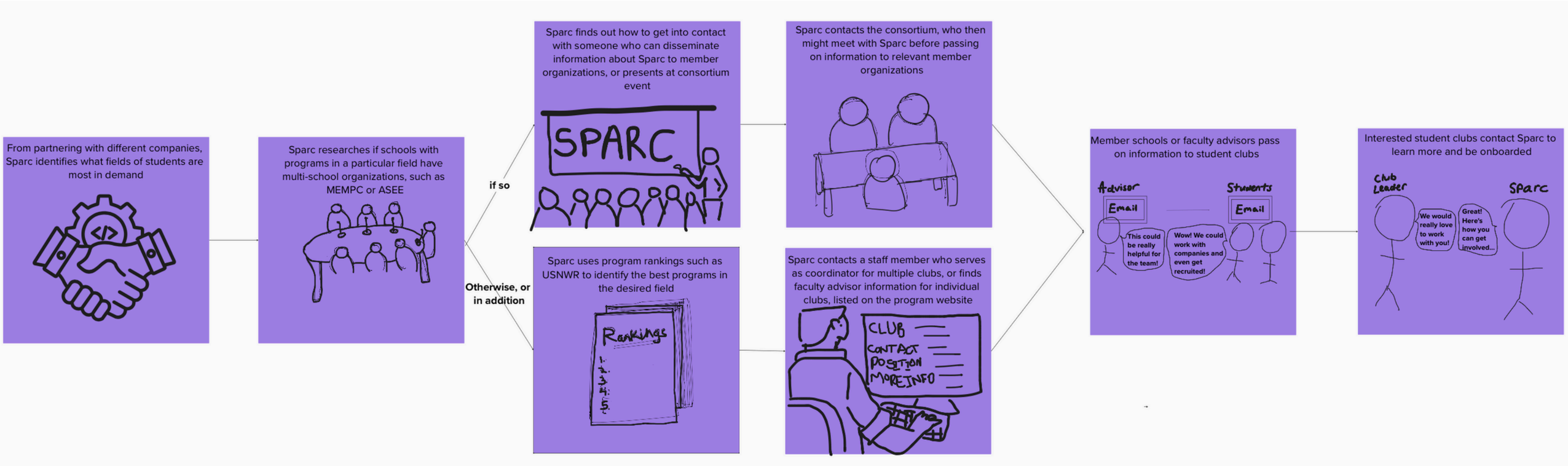
Sparc has already seen success in approaching student clubs directly, so scaling upwards by being able to onboard and connect with multiple clubs, and multiple universities, at once will allow for Sparc to become an even more attractive prospect for companies looking to partner with and recruit from universities and their clubs.

Sparc Design Challenge: Storyboards

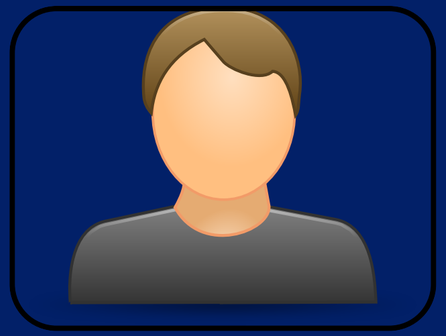
Sparc Interactive Job Postings with FAQ & Forum



Broader Methods for Connecting with Student Clubs



Sparc Design Challenge: User Personas



STUDENT SAM

- 20-25 years old
- STEM Education
- University Student
- Lives in dorms or in off-campus housing
- Prefers to communicate with texting, email, & social Media

BACKGROUND AND GOALS

Sam is a senior student passionate about problem solving and hands on projects. Sam Is actively looking for internship and job opportunities in their field of study or interests. They hope to network with industry professionals and recruiters to build meaningful connections and gain mentorship and career guidance from experts.

CHALLENGES

- Lack of professional connections or knowledge about how to start networking effectively.
- Difficulty accessing high-quality internships and job openings that align with their career goals.
- Uncertainty about which career path to pursue.

WHAT CAN WE DO

- Offer real-world group projects with companies, .
- Connect students with mentors through on-demand career coaching from professionals at top companies.
- Simplify the job search process.

REAL QUOTES

- “How do I network with more recruiters and organizations that align with my values?”
- “I want to be able to set up an infrastructure to collaborate with companies that my club can pass down from one group of students to the next each year”

COMMON OBJECTIVES

- To learn more about company and the role
- Do networking with the hiring manager and recruiter
- Need mentorship and guidance from industry experts to navigate career

MARKETING MESSAGING

“Creating a strong community for students and recruiters.”

ELEVATOR PITCH

Confused on what should be your next career step? Don't worry, the career coaches on our board will guide you further. Sparc not only helps you in making connections, but also helps you by listing job openings which you can apply to.

RECRUITER RILEY

- 25-35 years old
- American
- College-Educated
- Recruiter

BACKGROUND & GOALS

Riley is an educated older Gen Z/younger Millenial recruitment professional. They have experience with the current era of recruitment and see ways to improve the system to communicate better with young talent. They hope to find new ways to connect with students and new grads in order to attract them to their company.

CHALLENGES

- Overwhelmed by the volume of resumes and applications
- Difficulties in analysing student's growth and true potential beyond what is mentioned on their resumes.
- Competing with large companies for recruiting top talents
- Ensuring cultural fit as resumes don't always cover soft skills

WANTS

- To streamline the application process to make it quicker and less painful for everyone involved: their team, hiring managers, and candidates.
- To find top young talent that are the right fit and can be developed in order to guide Riley's company into its next era.

REAL QUOTES

- "We get a lot of resumes and its difficult to navigate through them and find out the ones who are truly suited for the roles."
- "We need better engagement with student clubs since its hard to make meaningful relationships with them to drive hiring."

COMMON OBJECTIVES

- Engagement with Sparc
- Connections between students and recruiters
- Streamline the recruitment process
- Nourish the company's brand on campuses

WHAT WE CAN DO

- Increase student group engagement with the Sparc platform
- Make it easier for Riley and their team to increase their engagement and organize meetings with student groups

ELEVATOR PITCH

Sparc simplifies the process for recruiters by building stronger relationships with student clubs and connect diverse high-potential pools of talent that are passionate about Riley's company's industry and available roles.

How personas will affect the ideation process

1. User personas help us identify our user needs because it gives us time to step into the shoes of our stakeholders and makes sure their priorities are taken into account
2. We can prioritize our ideas based on the real pain points of the users that needs to be addressed ensuring that the solutions we develop provide meaningful value
3. It helps us have more empathy towards our target users and brainstorm solutions that are not just innovative, but also practical and user-friendly
4. Personas help us broaden the team's perspective because consideration for people of different backgrounds is used to influence our work.

Upcoming research to create stronger personas

1. Conducting interviews with students, student clubs and recruiters to better understand what their pain points and desires are in the recruitment process.
2. To ensure that we are diversifying the stakeholders and that they all come from different backgrounds.
3. Collaborate with student clubs and career coaches to understand what role they play in the recruitment process and how can we improve those relationships.
4. Attend Career Fairs to observe how the interaction between students and recruiters takes place in real time to capture the insights that can help design the process better.